

Inherited asset records: find the evidence that changes the decision

The first useful result from an inherited data room is a map of what can be relied on, what conflicts and what must be checked in the field.

1. Organise around decisions

An archive organised only by document type is difficult to use for closure planning. Start with the decisions in front of the owner: define the inventory, establish isolation boundaries, select a removal method, identify a waste route or demonstrate the final condition. Then identify the evidence each decision needs.

This makes prioritisation more specific. A missing drawing for a redundant instrument may have little influence on an early option comparison. An unresolved discrepancy in a structural connection or a well barrier record can materially change the method or the next investigation. The same document gap has different significance at different stages of the project.

2. Separate identity, currency and adequacy

For each important record, establish what asset it describes, which revision it represents and what it actually demonstrates. "Latest available" does not necessarily mean as-built. "As-built" does not establish present condition. A certificate, drawing, inspection report and operating log answer different questions and should retain those distinctions in a digital system.

Keep conflicting records visible until they are resolved. A useful discrepancy register records the competing statements, the decision affected, the interim assumption, the accountable discipline and the evidence needed to close the issue. Replacing an inconvenient record with a newer file can erase the very uncertainty the project needs to understand.

01	02	03	04
Identify the record	Check relevance	Resolve conflicts	Record the decision

Fig. 03.1 / Illustrative decision sequence. Project-specific evidence and assessment remain necessary.

3. Verify the claims that carry consequence

Use targeted verification to test assumptions that affect the work. Examples include matching an equipment tag to the physical item, confirming a support arrangement, investigating an unrecorded modification or reconciling a cleaning record with the receiving facility's information needs. Survey and inspection should have a defined question and acceptance basis rather than a generic instruction to collect more data.

The evidence system should preserve original files and distinguish extraction from interpretation. A search result or AI-generated summary is a route into the record, not proof that the source is current, complete or technically applicable. Record the source location for extracted values and make engineering interpretations visibly attributable to a review step.

ASA 500's treatment of the relevance and reliability of information is useful comparative reading for this discipline of evidence. It is an auditing standard and does not prescribe a universal engineering document-control system. [ASA 500](#).

4. Connect the record to the asset's changing condition

An inherited record describes the asset at a time. Closure planning also needs an account of what has changed since then. Maintenance status, deterioration, modifications, isolation changes and access constraints can invalidate an earlier removal assumption without changing the original drawing.

NOPSEMA's March 2026 property policy discusses maintenance that enables safe removal. Its proactive-planning paper also connects late-life maintenance decisions with future decommissioning capability. These are regulatory sources for Commonwealth offshore context, not a substitute for asset-specific assessment. [Section 572 policy](#), [Planning for proactive decommissioning](#).

The deliverable is a decision-ready evidence register: supported claims, unresolved conflicts, consequential assumptions and the next verification actions. Counting files can describe an archive. It cannot establish whether an asset is ready for a closure decision.

Source notes

1. [ASA 500](#)
2. [Section 572 policy](#)
3. [Planning for proactive decommissioning](#)
4. [NOPSEMA Section 270 consent-to-surrender policy](#)

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